

Poor Man's Doon

A school started by a Gujarat corporate for poor children hopes to pitch them against the best of India in top notch professions with quality education.

Rajasthan

GUJARAT

AHMEDABAD

Maharashtra



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By Uday Mahurkar

Just before he died of an ailment in January 2007, Umesh Kadia, a construction labourer in Ahmedabad, told his wife that his dream was to make their daughter Khushi, 7, an engineer. Studying in Class II of a local school, Khushi had showed signs of brilliance. His dream seems to be coming true, thanks to an exceptional school opened by a corporate house. The English-medium Adani Vidyalaya in Ahmedabad, established by the Adani Foundation of the Gujarat-based Rs 25,000-crore Adani Group matches the high standards of any other good school except that it grants admission to children whose parents earn less than Rs 1 lakh annually. It provides free education and aims to make engineers, doctors and professionals out of the children of drivers, peons and labourers.

Khushi's mother heard about an advertisement issued by the school, inviting poor children for a written test for admission to Class III of the school. Khushi appeared for the test and cleared it. Today Khushi goes to school at 7 a.m. in a school bus and returns home only in the evening, after completing her homework at

school. The school provides her with breakfast, lunch and even evening refreshments. A group of committed teachers work overtime to ensure that the children switch over from Gujarati to English medium. Even though from poor backgrounds, students here have high ambitions. Says Trushabh Solanki, son of a bank peon who is from a Scheduled Caste: "I will become Mahendra Singh Dhoni in cricket." Similarly, Mayursinh Vaghela, the son of a factory worker, wants to become a soldier so that he can fight terrorists.

There are about 150 students in the school spread over 25,000 sq yards. Right now it has only two classes—III and IV. In three years, it will have classes up to XII and hopes to attract about 1,000 students. The school is run by noted academician N.V. Vasani and supervised by Priti Adani, wife of Adani Group chairman, Gautam Adani, along with sister-in-law Shilin. Adani says: "These kids will be able to compete with the best when they complete their studies." Quite possible for a school that has already spent Rs 40 crore besides reserving another Rs 30 crore for managing it. ■